

Scaling the Mission

How AI Is Accelerating Texas Czech Preservation

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The Race Against Time

450+

hours of recordings
awaiting transcription

54–92

speaker age range
documented in 2010
— now 16 yrs older

60:1

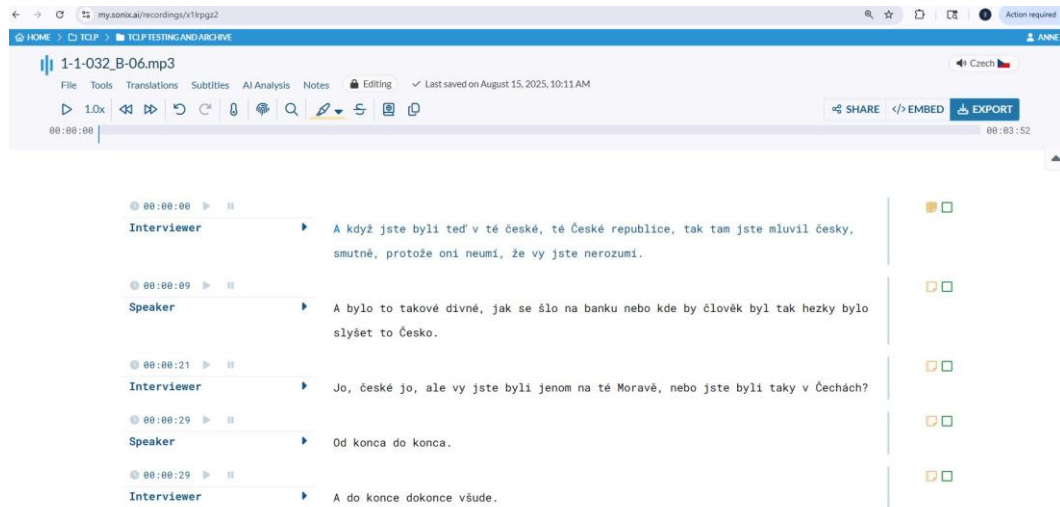
expert labor hours
previously required per hour
of audio (TCLP)

The youngest speakers documented in 2010 are now in their 70s.

At 60 hours of expert labor per hour of audio, completing 450+ hours requires 27,000+ hours of skilled work. The Jakobson archive alone holds 189 hour-long tapes. Add Cope (1997), Tomeček, Kučera — the backlog is vast.

Tool #1: SONIX

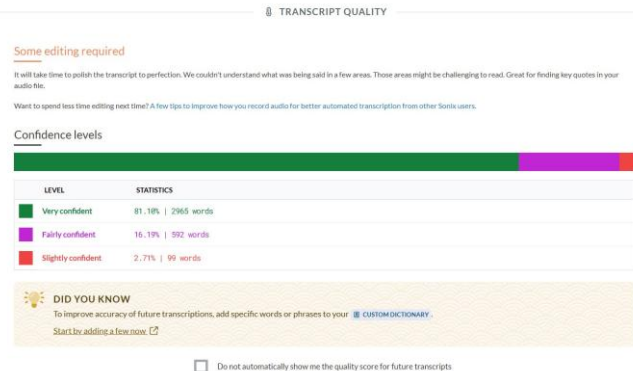
AI Transcription — First Draft, Not Final Word



The screenshot shows the SONIX web interface for a recording titled "1-1-032_B-06.mp3". The interface includes a playback control bar at the top with a progress bar at 00:00:00. Below the bar, there are tabs for "File", "Tools", "Translations", "Subtitles", "AI Analysis", "Notes", and "Editing". The "AI Analysis" tab is selected, showing a transcript with speaker labels and timestamps. The transcript is in Czech and includes the following text:

- Interviewer** (00:00:00): A když jste byli teď v té české, té České republice, tak tam jste mluvil česky, smutně, protože oni neumí, že vy jste nerozumíte.
- Speaker** (00:00:09): A bylo to takové divné, jak se šlo na banku nebo kde by člověk byl tak hezky bylo slyšet to Česko.
- Interviewer** (00:00:21): Jo, české jo, ale vy jste byli jenom na té Moravě, nebo jste byli taky v Čechách?
- Speaker** (00:00:29): Od konca do konca.
- Interviewer** (00:00:29): A do konce dokonce všude.

Each line of the transcript has a small icon to its right, likely for editing or highlighting.



The screenshot shows the "TRANSCRIPT QUALITY" section of the SONIX interface. It features a bar chart at the top with a green segment (Very confident) and a purple segment (Fairly confident). Below the chart is a table with the following data:

LEVEL	STATISTICS
Very confident	81.18% 2965 words
Fairly confident	16.19% 592 words
Slightly confident	2.71% 99 words

Below the table, there is a "DID YOU KNOW" section with a lightbulb icon and text: "To improve accuracy of future transcriptions, add specific words or phrases to your CUSTOM DICTIONARY. Start by adding a few now." There is also a checkbox labeled "Do not automatically show me the quality score for future transcripts".

Traditional pipeline: 60 hrs per 1 hr of audio. With SONIX: our transcriber reviews 10 min of audio in ~80-90 min — a 7x speedup on the correction phase.

Caveat: 8.5:1 covers transcription review only, not the full ELAN pipeline (translation, alignment, database formatting). End-to-end gain is real but partial.

Tool #2: From Transcript to Archive

The Prompt

Texas Czech Legacy Project — Transcript Analysis

I'm uploading a SONIX-output transcript (.docx) from the Texas Czech Legacy Project archive. Please do the following:

1. **Extract and analyze** the full transcript text. Do not correct anything in the transcript.
2. **Produce a topic index with timestamps** — granular, one entry per topic shift, with the timestamp, an **English-language title**, and an **English-language description** drawn from the SONIX output language.
3. **Identify probable people names and place names** from the transcript as-is, noting uncertainty where the SONIX rendering may be approximate.
4. **Group the granular topics into higher-level categories.** Use your judgment based on the content — typical categories have **Included English equivalents** of *Rodina a stěhování*, *Hospodářství a zemědělství*, *Společenský život a zábava*, *Tradice a zvyky*, and *Osobní vzpomínky a zdraví*, but derive the categories from what's actually in this transcript.
5. **Export everything as a Word document (.docx)** formatted as follows:
 - o Navy/blue color scheme (navy = #1F3B64, accent blue = #2E75B6)
 - o Arial font throughout
 - o Sections: Title block → Speakers → Annotator's Notes (if any in the source doc header) → Topic Index → Probable People Names → Probable Place Names → Notes for Reviewers
 - o Topic index as a two-column timestamped table, organized under the higher-level category headers (accent blue header rows spanning both columns, with **English category** title bold + **English subtitle** italic alongside)
 - o Names and places in three-column pill-style grids (light blue for names, light green for places)
 - o Notes for Reviewers section flagging uncertain SONIX renderings, dialect/loanword passages of interest, any singing or performance passages, and any passages a professor or interviewer explicitly flagged as important

The transcript is SONIX output targeting *Spisovná Čeština*. Do not correct anything — analyze and organize only.

The Output

Local Churches and Community Landmarks <i>Churches, chapels, local place names recalled</i>	
00:00:05	Layky kostel — Identifying a Lay Church Male 1 opens by naming what sounds like 'Layky kostel' (lay/secular church) and mentions 'Lessy' and possibly 'Pinda' as associated characters or nearby names. References Dubina and Stara Dubina.
00:00:25	Locating Dubina / Stara Dubina Female Interviewer asks where Dubina is; Male 1 attempts to give directions. Female Interviewer recognizes the place name.
00:01:00	Church Construction Date — 1913 Male 2 states the church was built/completed in 1913. Male 1 and Male 2 confirm 'dostaveny' (completed). Discussion of how construction began.
00:01:16	Second Church / Earlier Construction Male 1 refers to a 'Layky kostel' (paradise/heavenly church) and a second church. Difficult passage; mentions his father contributing stone to the church building.
Farming and Agricultural Life <i>Hay, crops, acreage, equipment, and labor</i>	
00:02:22	Livestock and Wanting Feed Outside Brief exchange about wanting to get feed/fodder out; rain is keeping them inside. Mention of cattle.
00:02:48	Hay vs. Maize (Corn) — Feed Crops Male 2 clarifies that what is being held outside is hay, not maize yet. Annotator flags 'maize' at 00:02:54.
00:03:04	First Hay Cutting of the Season Female Interviewer asks about the first hay cutting; Male 1 says it has not been cut yet due to rain. Discussion of ideal mowing conditions.
00:03:45	Field Size — 8 Acres of Meadow Male 1 mentions 8 acres (akry) of meadow/hay field. Annotator flags 'akry' (acres) as English loanword at 00:03:48.
00:03:51	Hay Cut by Machine Female Interviewer asks if the hay is cut by machine; Male 1 confirms yes.
00:03:55	Son's Role; Machinery and Weather Concerns

AI (Claude) organizes and flags. Human experts judge and correct. Dr. Cope's team retains all authority.

The Detective Story

“Czech Language in Texas” (1984) — the footage survives, the audio does not.

In 1984, folklorist Svatava Pírková-Jakobson filmed Texas Czech speakers for a documentary: **“Czech Language in Texas.”**

**The footage survives.
The audio does not.**

Jakobson also left behind a written **film script** — an “Argument for the Film.”

AI cross-referenced TCLP oral history transcripts against the script: names, places, dates, memories. Could we match voices to faces?

We found things.

Texas Czech Legacy Project — Film Audio Checklist						
Recordings relevant to the Jakobson documentary film (1984) For Dr. Cope's review						
CD / Recording	Speaker / Owner	Film Connection	Audio in hand?	SONIX transcription created?	SONIX transcript complete / put back into TX Czech?	Transcript Analysis document created?
GROUP 1 — Confirmed film speakers: audio processed						
CD_112_1	Fran/kaapoor	Script Scenes 10–11; Reels #400, #408	yes	yes		yes
CD_112_2	Hla Bile Wrebot.)	Script Scenes 10–11; Reels #400, #408	yes	yes		yes
GROUP 2 — Film speakers: SONIX + AI transcripts exist, but transcript analysis document not yet formatted						
CD_147_1	August A Roer; 1900 Lorrain: 11et 80	Script Scenes 6, 9, 25–28; Reel #410	yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_147_2	Boorits 2family (cont.)	Script Scenes 6, 9, 25–28; Reel #410	yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_153_1	Bessiers 5CPI)	Script Scenes 3–5, 13, 31; Reels #397, #402, #404	yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_153_2	Bessie 6/10ra/cont.)	Script Scenes 3–5, 13, 31 — verify if content exists	yes	NIL		
CD_113_1	Mucherek 10/10ra/cont.) (resent)	Cyril & Methodius topic; Moravia TX	yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_113_2	Mraete 10/10ra/cont.)	Velehrad mentioned; English/Czech mix	yes	spkr correction in progress		
GROUP 3 — Film speakers: transcripts exist - mostly in English						
CD_02_1	Irlighary	Script Scenes 1, 7; Reels #400, #402, #408, #410	used duplicate	N/A	N/A	N/A
CD_02_2	Irlighary 2/10ra/cont.)	Continuation — old days in English	used duplicate	N/A	N/A	N/A
CD_02a	Irlighary 1	Duplicate of CD_02_1	yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_02b	Irlighary 2	Duplicate of CD_02_2	yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_03_1	Irlighary 3 female speaker	Continuation: all English	yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_03a	Venodle ss	Duplicate of CD_03_1	duplicate of above	N/A	N/A	N/A
GROUP 4 — Possible film relevance						
CD_109_1/2	Embroidery specialist (unknown)	Thematic — folk art; quilting scenes Reels #407, #444	yes / yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_128_1	Older lady + younger male (Tatit at Jurica)	Jurica's store — Film #398, #411	yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_128_2	Very old male speaker	Jurica's store context — verify content	yes	spkr correction in progress		
CD_116_1	Moravia group singers	Film music scenes — choir practice with speech	yes	yes		
CD_155 a/b (tape)	8000 attendees incitbest	Reel #406 — Moravia Picnic auction	yes / yes	yes		



What AI Can — and Cannot — Do

AI CAN

- Process hundreds of hours of audio quickly
- Organize raw transcripts into structured documents
- Cross-reference names, dates, and places across recordings
- Flag uncertain passages for expert review
- Give human experts a running start

AI CANNOT

- Speak Texas Czech
- Hear the difference between a loanword and a transcription error
- Replace 25 years of fieldwork knowledge
- Make linguistic judgment calls
- Verify what the recordings actually say

AI multiplies human expertise. It doesn't replace it.

How You Can Help

Support Preservation

We are in an AI-assisted pilot phase — no financial ask today. Follow our progress on LinkedIn and stay connected as the project grows.

Volunteer

Do you know a filmmaker? We are looking for someone to help bring “Czech Language in Texas” back to life — editing, sound, restoration. Connections welcome.

Watch for Film News

Bringing the 1984 Jakobson documentary back to life is our next major milestone. No ask yet — but when the moment comes, we want you ready. Stay connected.

Texas Czech Legacy Project | Dr. Lida Cope, Director

<https://txczechproject.laits.utexas.edu/>

